Chapter Forty-Three

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Harsh Noise

01

CODY

Reed's father follows us as we descend the stairs, trying hard not to hover though his curiosity gets the best of him. As we pass aerospace merch from all the way back to Reed's great-grandfather, this Navidson house feels like I'm walking down a five-minute hallway.

"I don't get many friends that come all the way out here," Reed says, then mutters, "not really at all."

"It was a damn journey," I say. "My blood's so full of caffeine, I shouldn't have been driving."

It's hard not to pretend to notice the third set of footsteps behind us as Reed doesn't even notice. He says, "and I'm sorry about my parents: the whole best friend thing, you know."

"It's cool, bro. We've come a long way. I talk to my family about you guys all the time," I say, as we turn the corner of another span of double garages, finding cars parked three-in-a-line with different trophies from

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car shows on the walls. It's the only dirty room of the house, looking like it housed a tractor during their build process. The windows are covered, and when we enter, Pink Floyd's Comfortably Numb autoplays over the speakers.

I forget we're being followed when the double garage looks like a museum of beautiful, antiquated machines: an old LeBlond engine lathe from the 1940s, and another mill with a CNC retrofit, overtaking the manual controls with automatic displays that blink red and green. The wall holds a massive tap-and-die chart that even my grandma could read without her glasses: reminding me of the old machine shop back at university.

"She's been itching for action," Geoffrey says, and it startles me. "Sorry. I wanted to see you boys at work: white-collar management is so zoomed out from the battlefield, that it's nice to see some action from time to time."

"Sure," I say.

"Here's some trivia: you should know since you taught my boy the other day. Do you gear-shift the lathe before or after it's running?"

"Give him a second, Dad," Reed says. "At least let him set up first!"

"Before," I say. "It's gears."

Geoffrey wrings his calloused hands. "And what about the band saw, then?"

"It's belt-fed," I reply. "You can only change speeds when it's in motion." I almost destroyed the shop's band saw yesterday — the only reason I remember.

"Very good," Geoffrey says. "See? I hope you rub off more on Reed here. I had to coax him into being a gearhead..."

An uncommon expression clouds my friend's face, unable to respond to his father's calloused, nervous chatter at an unfamiliar guest in his home.

"He's rubbed off plenty on me," I say, deciding where to zero the hefty chunk of uneven metal: still branded with PROPERTY OF RUELAS, NO SCRAP.

"And how's that?" his father asks, expecting another joke.

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"Taught me how to be on a team," I say, and Reed's eyes lighten. I drive down the table of the mill's bed like I'm lowering an old car window, then lubricate the thirsty ways with a little oil. "I was a lost sheep for a while. He taught me how to make friends, I think. To care a little more. I mean, goddamn, your son's like the fuckin' sun—"

I cover my mouth when I realize I'm not in the shop anymore: this isn't some temporal enclave of the 1960s, despite all the hardware. Instead, I'm surprised to find that Geoffrey laughs, clapping Reed on the back.

"He sure is the friendmaker," his father says.

But his expression changes when he realizes the garage is about to be filled with harsh noise.

"So I heard you've got a presentation," he says.

I almost drop the chunk of aluminum.

"Yeah," I say.

"What happened was unfortunate. I only heard about it because of what Reed told me."

"Oh," I say.

"Reed told me about what your colleague found: you've got some good friends if they're working this hard to help you," Geoffrey says, but then he gets serious again, like he's giving me an early performance review, or negotiating a new salary. "Look. I came down here to tell you that the first I heard of any of that was from Reed, so as far as I know, your slate's clean."

"That's a relief," I say.

"But that doesn't mean you're close. I've been told your slot was last, which should help with recency bias — but Cody, you should consider this presentation your first interview."

I swallow, tasting coolant in the air. My hands nervously fumble with the hand wheel, feeling how real this has all become in such a short time.

"Do you have any questions for me?" He asks.

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I clamp the scrap to the table, setting my first datum. I'm ready to make my first pass on this project since college.

"How much time do I get?"

"Fifteen minutes in the Aspen conference room. Give them something to see outside, and maybe you'll have a while longer."

"A working demo," I say.

"Means you can't hide behind transitions in a PowerPoint."

I search through a bin of end mills, finding a flat-end one that matches the collet. The cacophony of noise gives me time to think. "So that means it will have to work the first time," I say.

"That's right."

I look down at the shattered piece I've come here to recreate. It's a stress fracture: sheared at forty-five degrees because the weight was too much, and I hope the next one is made of something better.

There's so much I've learned since the last time.

"I can do that," I say, tracing my finger against the malformed face of blistered metal. I grab the collet with my coolant-stained hands, chucking up an end mill with two shrill chirps from the pneumatic vise.

"If you treat your colleagues like how you've bonded with my son — and you show true passion for your craft — then you'll fit in well."

"Will do," I say.

His hand grasps the doorframe as he leans into the hallway.

"And one last thing," he adds.

"Yeah?"

"Please stay for dinner," he says, "and I'm not asking: my wife will kill me if Reed's mysterious friend stays an anecdote."

"I'll stay," I say. *Or else I won't eat.*

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02

KATIYA

I lack the time to explain before my allies turn on each other, and though Jade feels exhausted from bending time to a near stop, she still manages to slow the world enough for the two of us that they can't hear my words.

Sylvia drew her bow with Essenced arrows as soon as we appeared in a flash of light — and when she saw my panicked expression from weathering another long, short trip, she identified Jade as the enemy, refusing to take any chances.

Jade tenses the polished sphere in her claws: she might not be driving its magic, but it looks like she's the one that's now doing the pulling. A low thrum rattles the bowstring when Sylvia's nocked arrow leaves her fingers, flying fast enough to challenge Jade's grasp of time. The flint arrowhead combusts with white-hot Human Essence, and Titus unsheathes his sword, resonating with another loud hum.

"Aliaki," Jade mutters, and I hear someone coming to even the odds. The sphere scrolls rapidly as the anchor point shifts, and as Sylvia's first arrow crosses half the distance between our two parties, Jade reaches to grab it by its end.

The blistering heat doesn't have the time to sear her flesh and fur, but she winces when she turns it back around, hurling it directly for Titus' head. This extra lapse of time already burdens her enough — like holding back the flow of a powerful river — and as the world begins to settle, shuddering with the urge for progress like tired muscles on their last effort, Aliaki arrives in another flash.

I reach desperately for the rogue arrow, but time no longer waits. Titus refuses to flinch though a white death stares him in the forehead, and in an instant, the flint head erupts into tiny flecks of molten rock.

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The shaft combusts into soot, decorating Titus' face with a flash of dark powder. He thinks he has the space to charge an attack as Jade fails to negotiate any more with time, raising his sword to charge, but Aliaki clenches her fist faster.

The pale light in front of us shifts blue. Twenty yards crunches into twenty inches, and before Titus can realize he's been shorted on his approach, Aliaki withdraws a plug from the large waterskin on her back, drenching her fibrous flesh. It goes dry in an instant, and she grows from a meager five feet to more than seven.

Titus tries to shift his weight with fewer steps to gain momentum. I throw myself between the two of them to try to get them to stop, but I've been shorted for just as much space.

Aliaki materializes a spear she's kept in some space between spaces, and lunges at the fearless human, about to make contact with his heart before I nudge the weapon just in time. It pierces through his armpit, but Sylvia can't see his face to know he's fine: that the spear is nothing more than a graze, and when she shouts his name, she invokes a strength from somewhere within that feels more powerful than any of us.

Her hair glows white with the light of a thousand suns: one trapped in each strand of hair, and we feel our bodies overcome with something ethereal that casts us to our knees. It's only when my hands touch both of their chests — a conduit of peace between Aliaki and Titus — that their adrenaline quiesces, and Titus drops the spear from between his arm, along with his blade that Aliaki condensed to a tenth of its length.

"Give reality a rest," I say, "you're going to break it!"

"These are surely not your friends," Aliaki says. "Refugees, they said? They're lying!"

"And who the Res are you?" Titus asks: the two push against my hands, and I feel like an insect stopping two mountains of Essence from colliding, but they don't push hard. Jade catches her breath as she sits on the ground: sweat cleansing her golden coat of all the dirt, and it shimmers in the pale light.

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"I recognize him now. It was him," Aliaki says. "In the frames of every forgotten world: I saw his lifeless husks in all the realities he left behind."

"So he's the anomaly," Jade says.

"No. He's something different. And he sacrificed his gift to shed no more."

"I've come to peace now," Titus says, as Sylvia takes his arm. "I'm an outcast for what I've done, but if you witnessed even a moment . . . of all those ends, can you understand what it was all for?"

She pauses, drawing a breath of our exhale. "It must have been madness. But you completed your mission."

"A circular path only ends when you decide to stop," Titus says. "I left the circle."

"And it brought you here." Aliaki turns to me. "Fate brings us to the same mooring point: to her, no more than a common soldier, and yet the linchpin of three Masks of the gods."

"So you know about Sylvia," Titus says.

Jade's eyes narrow, exposing thin green slits. "But she's one of the Chosen, Ali — right? Isn't it four?"

"Her class hasn't been in this world since the Second Awakening. She's the incarnation of something far, far older: maybe she doesn't even know it."

"I have an idea," Sylvia says.

"Then it seems that fate points us all in the same direction," Jade says. She lifts herself from the ground after taking Gaffesend's dirt in her clutches, muting the shimmer in her strands. "I came to tell Katiya of an ambush from the west, but what I didn't tell her . . . is that it was futile."

I squint. "What do you mean by that?"

"That I was relaying a message, so your people had a chance to save themselves. Aliaki found a source of tremendous Chymaeran energy in the northern wastes of Blackwater, and she thought that if she could save

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them — and bring them into the light — that this Mask might be able to delay the incursion."

"What mask?" Titus asks. "There were only two. And now I'm the only one."

Aliaki says, "They should be headed here now, shepherded by two other Blackwater refugees. That is, if she's survived the transmutation: her soul will be split."

"Well, is it now the whole truth?" I ask. "Is there anything else important that you're hiding?"

"I'm sorry," Jade says. "Aliaki and I are in the service of a greater mission than Gaffesend: to reclaim a stolen empire, and this was meant to be a warning. We were headed to Northaven—"

"These are a people," Titus says. "You're privileged to a truth, and that truth binds you to a responsibility." He grabs his wrist with all the threaded scars. "That makes you their hope, even if you don't ask for it."

"And that hope has changed with new information." Jade looks between the four of us. "They can't predict what even I was unaware of, so it means we have a real shot," then she looks at me. "And you're the one that fate decides will bring this all together."

03

CODY

I return home full and exhausted with a clean, new replacement part. They sent me home with expensive glass Tupperware containers that "you can send home with Reed," packed with cuts of tri-tip Geoffrey seared and grilled.It has a whole two shelves of space to breathe in my fridge, besides a Costco trip from mom, Katiya's Chinese leftovers, and a rack of Pabst Blue Ribbon that gives me a taste of college.My muscles ache from the chatter of the machines. Micro-abrasions on my fingers sting with hand

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sanitizer, and I'm about to head up to take a shower when I hear the sound of crying next door. So instead I grab the leftovers, inching my way through Katiya's door with a container, slow enough to not invoke the wrath of another stranger. I think it's Rayna at first glance, sitting on Katiya's couch in her foyer, but then there's a copy of her. They both look like Rayna. The double doesn't cry: she just stares at her reflection with piercing blue eyes. I knock on the door lightly, yet the two catgirls jump."Intruder!" One of them says."Cody," Rayna says. The name brings the other to lower her weapon. "What's happening this time? Did you duplicate yourself?""This is Aryn," Rayna says, "my sister.""Who are you?" Aryn asks, but she squints harder. "Wait, I remember you — you were outside this house. The noble. That Royal Inventor that got the slice on the hand.""That's me," I say, while Rayna sniffles. "I heard crying next door. What's going on?""An unexpected reunion. A dead girl walked into my town, and I found out that she's my sister." She turns back to Rayna, raising her voice again. "Was Katiya hiding you here the whole time? Is that why she was so secretive?""I'm only here because I forced myself upon her goodwill," Rayna says. "She has nothing to do with this.""I thought she was mourning!" Aryn slams the coffee table, and her sister jumps."She still is," Rayna says."I trusted her, and she used that trust to hide everything," Aryn says. "You should have come to me. Or at least — why didn't you go home? Mom and Dad could have protected you. They would give anything."Rayna sniffles, lowering her head even further. "So why, Rayna? Tell me," Aryn says, flashing the contours of her fangs. "Now!""Take it easy," I say. She glares hard enough to drive me back a couple steps, then tries to soften her voice, but the anger still abrades the words in her throat. "Just tell me," Aryn says. "Please—""I couldn't bear it," Rayna says."Bear what?" Aryn says."I couldn't bear to face you," Rayna says. "But we swore to protect each other, no matter what, and I don't care if you're in trouble. You're my sister.""I was better off dead to you. And that choice made you a whole lot greater than I could ever be, because you deserved—"Aryn slaps her sister across the face, and Rayna recoils against the couch. "You don't get to decide that for us. You made a promise," Aryn says, "and you're so much more to me alive..."Aryn raises her hand again, but it falls to her side. Rayna grasps her cheek. I can't shake the thought all I ever wanted, for years, was to yell the same way at my sibling after they left for the last time — but watching how it plays out secondhand is painful."Hey," I say. "Let's continue next door. You both seem hungry.""And why the Res would we do that?" Aryn asks. "You're interrupting something

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—"I open the lid, and her expression quickly changes. "Well . . . fine. But I'm not even close to done with her.""That's fine," I say, wedging the door back open with my foot as I accept it's going to be a long night. "Sit down on the couch, and I'll prepare something for you."Aryn still hesitates. It's hard to convince cats to do anything, so I act indifferent, rushing in to shutter my shades to forestall a deluge of difficult questions. They enter my world with a few steps at a time, then deposit themselves on the couch, as Aryn gears up to deliver another verbal lashing, but she's forestalled by the oddness of my world.I toss the glassware in the microwave as I think of all the things I longed to tell him, the thoughts so fresh in my mind that they were almost practiced.And they're still there. It takes the full three presses of the microwave's START button to even start to sort them out, and by the time I'm balancing the leftovers between two plates — and I serve them in the foyer — I open my mouth, feeling all the sadness of the last decade wash over me. When they see I've stopped holding back, they listen: my body shivers when I return to living in his last moments, but this time, it's no longer forced upon me by a nightmare. A day of exhaustion tears back the mechanisms that might protect me, without space for isolation or irony to invent an escape."Even through all this anger, you have a chance to start again," I say. "I never got that."They blink at me, hesitating to take their first bite until I finish the thought."There's not a second I've lived since my brother died that I've been able to call my own," I confess, then I gasp, and it startles me: struggling to remember the last time I ever choked on a feeling.

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